

Q The palms of my hands are red and hot. Is this a recognized side effect of pregnancy?

Around 30 percent of pregnant women get a condition called **plantar erythema**, which causes reddening in the palms, and in the fleshy pads underneath your thumbs and little fingers. It sometimes also appears on the soles of the feet. The condition is a result of higher estrogen levels, which increase the amount of blood in your circulatory system. This in turn raises your body temperature and how warm your extremities feel and how red they appear. The condition is nothing to worry about and will go away after you've had your baby. If the reddening is bothering you, though, simply do what you can to keep your hands cool.

Q My hair is much thicker than it was before I got pregnant. Will it stay like this forever?

No, it won't. All that thick, glossy hair isn't just the result of increased levels of sebum (your body's natural oil) over your scalp. Higher levels of progesterone in the second and third trimesters of pregnancy mean that you don't shed hair in the way that you did when you weren't pregnant. However, when your hormone levels fall dramatically after the baby is born, you shed all the excess hair over a much shorter period of time, so it can appear as if clumps of hair are falling out daily. So, unfortunately, the locks you love now aren't forever, but don't worry—after the birth, your hair is simply returning to its normal thickness.

Q I have tiny red and blue lines on my face and neck. Will they go away?

It's possible that you have some temporary "spider veins" appearing on your face, neck, shoulders and chest. They are simply where the very finest walls of your capillaries, close to the surface of your skin, have broken under the strain of the increased amount of blood in your circulation. They will usually disappear of their own accord once you've had the baby. Blue veins due to increased blood flow to breast tissue may become more noticeable.

Q I've heard that pregnant women are prone to tooth decay. Why is this, and how can I prevent it?

It's an old wives' tale that pregnancy rots your teeth. However, it is true that you're more susceptible to bleeding gums and gum disease, particularly if you had weakened gums before you got pregnant.

The weakening of the connective tissue that can lead to stretch marks can also make your gums softer and liable to tearing. Also, your saliva is now more acidic, which can exacerbate the effects. This can lead to infection and damaged teeth.

Reducing your sugar intake to protect your teeth and gums and good hygiene is essential. It's also a very good idea to keep up with your regular dental checkups and

cleanings with the hygienist (which is typically every six months). If you do need essential dental work, it is fine to have a local anesthetic during the second trimester. There is no risk to your baby. Some dentists believe that because gum disease is linked with premature birth, it's better for the mother to have dental treatment when it's needed rather than waiting until after the baby's birth.

DENTAL CARE WHILE PREGNANT

The checklist below will ensure that you are clear about the things you need to do, what to tell your dentist and procedures that should be avoided.



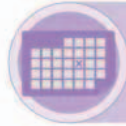
» **Maintain good hygiene** using a soft toothbrush and floss regularly. Always brush after a meal, but be gentle, and use a nonalcohol-based mouthwash to help remove residual bacteria.



» **Tell your dentist that you are pregnant** when you schedule your appointment. You should inform your dentist about any medication you are taking since some might affect the development of your child's teeth.



» **Tell your dentist** if tenderness, bleeding, or gum swelling occurs at any time during your pregnancy.



» **Avoid dental treatment** during the first trimester and the second half of the third trimester (the last six to eight weeks), as these are key times in the baby's growth and development.



» **Avoid dental X-rays** during pregnancy. If an X-ray is absolutely essential, your dentist will be extra vigilant to keep your baby safe, and most dental X-rays don't affect the abdomen.



» **Postpone all elective**, nonessential dental procedures until after the delivery.



» **Avoid having an amalgam (silver) filling** removed or put in during pregnancy, as a precautionary measure.